the public announcement. I was quite pleased about this prospective development, since like Y.V. Reddy, my choice for governor too would have been Rakesh. Besides, I had built a comfortable professional relationship with him, which meant that we would be able to handle the inevitable differences between the government and the RBI in an objective and agreeable manner.

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Interview for the Job of Governor

Finance Minister Chidambaram was usually the first one to check into North Block, the imposing building on Rajpath that houses the ministry of finance, every workday morning. After a few months of working with him, I realized that this early-morning slot was the best time to touch base with him if I had to discuss any urgent issue before the day's schedule engulfed both of us.

So it was that on Tuesday, 26 August, I had gone to catch the finance minister during this short morning window mainly to tell him that I would be leaving that night for Brazil to attend the G20 Deputies meeting. As my minister, Chidambaram had approved my foreign travel, but that was some time ago and the exact dates of my absence from office may not have stayed in his mind. In particular, I needed to check if he wanted me to attend to anything before I left.

My hunch was right as he went into some silent calculation when I told him about my trip. He asked when I would be back and when that date registered on his mind, he paused briefly and asked me if I would be interested in being considered for the governor's job. Frankly, I was surprised. Notwithstanding all the media speculation, I thought that the prime minister and Chidambaram had decided on Rakesh as the next governor. Even before I replied, he offered that I could think about it and let him have my answer by lunchtime.